

## KRAKOW, PAST PERFECT

Krakow feels immediately legible in a way that Warsaw resists. Its Main Market Square displays medieval confidence, church towers rising above cafe umbrellas, and the long shadow of Wawel Cathedral marking the city's former role as Poland's royal heart. There is pageantry here: Gothic altars, Renaissance courtyards, history preserved rather than reconstructed. South of the Old Town lies Kazimierz, the former Jewish quarter. Synagogues, courtyards, and narrow lanes carry history into the present. By evening, the district shifts personality again, as jazz clubs and cellar bars fill historic structures with live music and conversation.

To understand the communist period, head east to Nowa Huta. Built after the Second World War as a planned socialist city, it was organised around wide avenues, monumental housing blocks, and the steelworks that defined its purpose. At its centre stands the Lord's Ark Church, built after years of resistance from the communist authorities.



The Wieliczka Salt Mines just outside Krakow are simply astounding. Among the first sites inscribed on UNESCO's World Heritage list in 1978, this 13th-century mining complex reveals centuries of labour beneath the earth. Descending a shaft roughly 64 metres below ground, visitors enter an underground labyrinth of tunnels, chambers, brine pools, and galleries. Much of the complex, including its chambers and artworks, has been carved from grey-green rock salt by generations of miners. At the centre lies the vast Chapel of Saint Kinga, where sculptures, altarpieces, bas-reliefs, and even chandeliers fashioned from salt crystals emerge from the walls. The space gathers work, faith, and craftsmanship into a single, almost unbelievable cathedral deep underground.





Public fountains punctuate Krakow (above); St. Bartholomew's Church in Krakow-Mogiła is a striking example of historic wooden architecture (Left); Wawel Royal Castle, Krakow, is a defining symbol of Poland's royal past (Far left)